

ONLY GOOD FENCES KEEP GOOD NEIGHBOURS! THE INSTITUTIONALIZATION OF MINISTRY-AGENCY RELATIONSHIPS AT THE SCIENCE-POLICY NEXUS IN GERMAN FOOD SAFETY POLICY

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This article makes a further contribution to opening the 'black box' of micropractices in ministry–agency relationships. We argue that the mechanisms that come into play in the course of institutionalizing agencification reforms – such as renegotiating mutual roles and rules in ministry–agency interactions – are only poorly covered in the existing literature. To adequately address the negotiated and contingent nature of *de facto* agency autonomy and political control, we develop an interpretive approach based on the concept of 'boundary work'. The empirical focus is on ministry–agency interactions at the science–policy nexus in the contested policy field of food safety. By studying actors' stories about the institutionalization processes following the fundamental reorganization of the German food safety administration in the wake of the BSE crisis from a longitudinal perspective, we show how actors manage boundary conflicts via increasingly differentiated backstage coordination.

INTRODUCTION

For almost two decades, a growing body of literature within public administration has focused on agencification reforms – that is, the delegation of regulatory and other state competencies to various forms of formally semi-autonomous bodies (e.g. Pollitt *et al.* 2001; Gilardi 2005; Christensen and Lægreid 2006; Van Thiel *et al.* 2012). While this research has provided important insights, for example with regard to the lack of a clear relationship between *formal* and *de facto* autonomy of agencies, it is still struggling to capture the mechanisms that come into play in the course of the institutionalization of the agencification reforms in practice (Yesilkagit 2004). To adequately address microlevel institutionalization dynamics, such as the renegotiation of mutual roles and rules in ministry–agency relationships, we concur with other recent contributions to the field in arguing that much is to be gained from adopting an interpretive approach to the agencification phenomenon (Moynihan 2006; Flinders 2009; Smullen 2010; Hay 2011; Elston 2014).

This article sets out to address this microlevel practice gap by interpreting the institutionalization of agencification within a specific setting, namely the science–policy nexus in German food safety policy, which was fundamentally reorganized in the wake of the BSE crisis in the early 2000s. To explore the question how the intra- and inter-organizational role understandings and practices in ministry–agency relationships changed after reorganization, we develop a heuristic allowing us to conceptualize *de facto* agency autonomy as the result of 'boundary work' (Gieryn 1983). Methodically, we draw on narrative data from semi-structured, personal expert interviews conducted with various members of the organizations involved.

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WHY WE NEED AN INTERPRETIVE APPROACH TO AGENCY AUTONOMY

In the 1990s scholars began to observe a growing number of semi-autonomous agencies spreading across countries and sectors, resulting in the metaphorical diagnosis of 'agency-fever' (Pollitt *et al.* 2001). In addition to mapping, assessing, and explaining the rise and renewal of agency landscapes, agencification research has focused on conceptualizing and empirically assessing 'agency autonomy'. A major analytical distinction is made between formal autonomy ('the level of decision-making competencies') and de facto autonomy ('the exemption of constraints on the actual use of decision-making competencies') (Verhoest *et al.* 2004, p. 104). According to this conception, autonomy is inherently a *quantitative* phenomenon. This has considerable implications for how agency autonomy is approached empirically, namely in terms of the varying *degrees* of formal or de facto autonomy.

Most of the scholars focusing on de facto autonomy attempt to measure the autonomy of executive agencies on the basis of large-*N* survey research (Verhoest *et al.* 2012). One remarkable finding states that in a number of countries there is still a considerable degree of political control over the operational work of agencies. A higher degree of formal autonomy hence does not always imply a higher degree of de facto autonomy (e.g. Yesilkagit and Van Thiel 2008; Maggetti 2012). At the same time, however, the patterns of autonomy and control in the actual ministry–agency interactions are contingent on different contextual factors (Verhoest *et al.* 2012). These survey results lend some support to critiques questioning one of the dominant New Public Management myths: namely, the possibility and universal rationality of a clear separation between politics/policy (having the primacy) and bureaucracy.

Studying Dutch agencies, Yesilkagit and Van Thiel (2008) conclude that the relationships between autonomy and control are highly complex and that the question remains how mechanisms of control work in practice, given the high degree of influence that the agencies ascribed to governmental actors, according to their survey. Discussing the method used, they finally argue that the question of the practical operation of autonomy and control, that is, the way in which agencies respond to external expectations, requires 'a more dynamic approach' than survey research permits (Yesilkagit and Van Thiel 2008, p. 152). Roness *et al.* (2008, p. 168) argue that such findings, which draw a rather messy picture of how the patterns of autonomy and control function in practice, are entirely plausible considering the deeply *negotiated* and *contingent* nature of agency autonomy. Finally, Verhoest *et al.* (2010), though supporting basic claims made by 'task-specific path-dependence theory' (Pollitt *et al.* 2004), suggest that there should be a stronger focus in future research on 'the mechanisms and logics in the minds of the key actors involved' (Verhoest *et al.* 2010, p. 269).

This brief literature overview shows that while previous research has produced important insights, several questions remain unanswered: How do actors use and understand the concept of agency autonomy and political control? What mechanisms come into play in the course of the institutionalization of the agency model, for example in terms of 'role purification' (Christensen and Lægreid 2006), following the establishment of new agencies (Yesilkagit 2004)? If the agency model is contested, how does this contestation take place, and how might the model reassert itself in the face of contestations? How do the different institutional logics of politics, bureaucracy, and other social spheres shape organizational sensemaking processes with regard to the agency model?

Answering questions such as these, we argue, requires us to supplement the existing research by adopting an interpretive microperspective on agencification. In the following, we shall thus develop a heuristic enabling us to address the microlevel of sensemaking in institutionalization processes.

STUDYING AGENCIFICATION THROUGH INTERPRETIVE LENSES

In line with a phenomenological view of institutions (Meyer 2008), we address the microlevel of institutionalization as a *process* – rather than as a *property* – by drawing on the conceptualization of institutionalization in which ‘sensemaking’ and ‘boundary work’ are key discursive mechanisms.

Tolbert and Zucker (1996, p. 181) refer to institutionalization as a ‘set of sequential processes – habituation, objectification and sedimentation’. In a preinstitutionalization phase (habituation), there is little sense for the necessity and the general utility of a new structural arrangement (p. 181). Habituation is followed by processes of objectification in which some form of social consensus concerning the value of new structures in problem-solving is created within or between organizations. This consensus emerges when the new arrangement is justified as a solution to the pre-identified problem using logical or empirical argumentation (p. 183). Hence, objectification involves the development of general, shared social meanings attached to new structural arrangements (Zucker 1977). Finally, when there is historical continuity in practising the new structural arrangements, they are gradually completely institutionalized (sedimentation). The practices are then transmitted to new members of the organization who lack knowledge of their origins and are apt to treat them as ‘social givens’ (Tolbert and Zucker 1996, p. 181).

Whereas Tolbert and Zucker (1996) are particularly concerned with the emerging structures and practices on the mesolevel of organizational fields, Weick (1995, p. 36) focuses on microlevel sensemaking as the ‘feedstock of institutionalization’. According to Weick, the way actors interpret new structural arrangements is influenced by their initial identity constructions (pp. 18–24). What actors think they are (identity construction) as organizational actors affects how they interpret new roles and rules (Weick *et al.* 2005, p. 409). Moreover, from a sensemaking perspective, identity constructions are shaped by how actors are viewed by others: ‘Who we are lies importantly in the hands of others, which means our categories for sensemaking lie in their hands’ (p. 409). Using Weick’s understanding of sensemaking processes we can analyse how actors make sense of reform models on the basis of initial identities that inform the meaning they attribute to newly established organizational structures.

With Weick, we can also focus on how actors’ initial identities come to be destabilized and more receptive to new meanings. He allows us to see how this occurs within processes that involve changes in how actors are viewed by others. These changes typically occur when new rules and roles are habituated, objectified, and sedimented following organizational reforms that disrupt established organizational norms and world views (p. 416). Moreover, Weick teaches us that ‘sensemaking is about organizing through communication’ (p. 413). Yet, his sensemaking approach provides us with no guidance as to how the different communicative micropactices involved in the way actors make sense of new roles and rules can be analytically distinguished.

We argue that the concept of ‘boundary work’ (Gieryn 1983), originating in science studies, helps us to understand how actors struggling to make sense of their changing roles

in institutional reforms deal with contradictory institutional logics. According to Gieryn (1983), scientific actors are constantly working on drawing and redrawing the boundaries between science and other knowledge forms in order to maintain the epistemic authority of scientific actors in judging truth. Boundary work is, however, not only a discursive strategy for maintaining scientific autonomy. It is also a discursive device used to *expand* the scientific field of influence into areas dominated by actors from different social spheres, such as politics or bureaucracy (or vice versa), and to coordinate the different and in part contradictory expectations (Hoppe 2005). It is thus a useful heuristic for reconstructing the discursive strategies used by actors at the science–policy nexus in (re)negotiating their roles and rules governing their interactions. However, it would be misleading to assume that boundary work is a *purely* rational-intentional practice as the term of ‘boundary work strategies’ might imply. Rather, reflexive actors draw on institutional frames and logics to both emergently and deliberately account for why a boundary is (or is not) legitimately drawn, maintained or overstepped.

BOUNDARY WORK ANALYSIS: OPERATIONALIZATION AND METHOD

We distinguish between three types of boundary work strategies at the science–policy interface (table 1). *Demarcation* is a discursive device to uphold autonomy that entails disclaiming external expectations as normatively illegitimate, thereby advocating indifference to all but one’s own criteria of relevance and legitimacy (Jung 2014). Applying this to ministry–agency interactions at the science–policy nexus means that the demarcation device is used by ministries to protect political decision-making processes from attempts by scientific advisory agencies to impose their scientific logic on these processes. Conversely, demarcation can also be used by scientific advisory agencies to ward off ministries wishing to have a say in the agency’s internal processes of knowledge production and communication (Korinek and Veit 2013).

Expansion involves the expectation that actors from other social spheres will adapt to one’s own norms and standards, while again framing external demands as illegitimate (Jung 2014). Applied to our object of study, expansion is about ministerial attempts to

TABLE 1 *Discursive devices of boundary work (own compilation, based on Korinek and Veit 2013)*

Boundary work device	Operationalization
1. Demarcation	Ministry/agency disclaim others’ expectations as normatively illegitimate and advocate the demarcation of external demands ⇒ maintaining autonomy of political decision-making/scientific knowledge production
2. Expansion	Ministry/agency claims that the other party has to adapt to their own criteria of rationality, while warding off external demands at the same time ⇒ scientization of politics/politicization of science
3. Strategic adaptation	Ministry/agency claims that its own adaptation to the other’s demands is both normatively legitimate and strategically necessary ⇒ reflexivization of politico-administrative decision-making/scientific knowledge production

TABLE 2 *Institutionalization and boundary discourses (own compilation)*

Institutionalization phase	Boundary discourse
Habitualization <i>Uncertainty and conflict about new roles and rules</i>	⇒ expansion and demarcation discourses dominate over strategic adaptation discourses
Objectification <i>Working consensus on the definition of new roles and rules</i>	⇒ strategic adaptation discourses dominate over demarcation and expansion discourses
Sedimentation <i>Taken for grantedness of new roles and rules</i>	⇒ strategic adaptation discourses marginalize expansion and demarcation discourses

politicize the agency's work in the field of scientific knowledge production and attempts by agencies to scientize politico-administrative decision-making (Korinek and Veit 2013).

However, actors also claim at times that adaptation to external demands is both normatively legitimate and strategically necessary in terms of their own identity-bound motives. *Strategic adaptation* is thus a third device of boundary work (Jung 2014). Ministries concede agency autonomy and adapt to scientific expert logic only when and where scientific autonomy is deemed a useful means for achieving political goals such as publicly demonstrating policy credibility. Independent or semi-autonomous scientific advisory agencies, in turn, adapt to political needs only where and when they regard the primacy of politics as a legitimate and necessary means for realizing their own strategies. Thus, strategic adaptation is about negotiating when, where, and why scientific advisory agencies should adapt to politico-administrative expectations and vice versa, with actors thereby becoming more reflexive in their own identity and expectations in relation to other identities and expectations. Table 1 summarizes this operationalization.

Turning to the empirical material, it is reasonable to assume that in any organizational-institutional setting all three discursive devices of boundary work are present (Jung 2014). Yet, we claim that we can observe a hierarchical pattern of these boundary work discourses at particular time periods along Tolbert and Zucker's (1996) institutionalization route. Combining the three devices of boundary work with these three phases of institutionalization leads us to expect the following patterns (table 2):

1. In the phase of habitualization, conflict about new roles and rules, expansion and demarcation discourses will be dominant due to a lack of understanding of the usefulness of the new reform model.
2. As time passes, the prime narratives making sense of the new structural arrangement, however, might change. The concepts of autonomy/control might shift from being predominantly framed as an illegitimate and dysfunctional expansion of authority by both parties to being portrayed as normatively legitimate and necessary for achieving organizational goals. The story then is primarily about explaining why strategically adapting to external rationalities is both appropriate and necessary and about why, accordingly, actors should concede autonomy in certain respects or accept political control in other respects. In this case, when strategic adaptation discourses dominate over expansion and demarcation discourses, we can speak of an objectification of the new arrangement.

3. While expansion discourses will still be visible and partly challenge the dominance of demarcation and strategic adaptation discourses in the objectification phase, they become generally marginalized if and when the new reform model is sedimented. Thus, in the phase of sedimentation, when the negotiated roles and rules become taken for granted, strategic adaptation is the widely unquestioned dominant discourse.

Methodology

Following what Ospina and Dodge (2005) called 'the narrative turn in public administration', we analyse these 'boundary discourses' as they manifest themselves in the stories that members from different levels within ministries and agencies tell. The aim of this narrative analysis is to understand how particular collective stories legitimizing or delegitimizing agency autonomy become dominant in the process of institutionalization and how they act as a means of resocialization that prescribes or reinforces particular actions. By analysing the way a storyteller includes or excludes, emphasizes or de-emphasizes, particular experiences or actions, we can reconstruct how the teller interprets the events and actions that have occurred and how she evaluates how things used to be, how they are, and how they should be (Czarniawska 1998; Feldman *et al.* 2004).

Data collection

We drew our narrative data from different fieldwork sources. These included interviews and official documents such as guidelines and conference documentation, as well as field notes taken during participant observation of two public events organized by the BfR (triangulation). We conducted 23 semi-structured expert interviews from June 2011 to August 2012, which lasted from 45 to 120 minutes. They were all fully and precisely transcribed with advanced rules including cross talk and long pauses. We assumed that the stories told and received would vary according to the various organizational loci and therefore selected interviewees in positions ranging from agency presidents, heads of divisions and subdivisions to section leaders and heads of research groups and laboratories. The interviews probed how the organization members had experienced the changes connected to the agencification reform in practice and addressed broader sets of different themes covering more general issues such as 'policy change', or 'evidence-based policymaking' and 'risk communication', as well as the nitty-gritty details of intra- and inter-organizational coordination.

Data analysis

In accordance with the interpretive focus of the study, we applied a reconstructive sequence-oriented microanalysis, proceeding in two steps.

First, we analysed the stories in the *microcontext* of the sequences in which they occurred. Here, we focused as much as possible on the narrative data themselves – that is, the form, content, and structure of the story told. Within this, we devoted particular attention to the storytellers' use of personal, temporal, and spatial deixis (Krzyżanowski 2010, p. 88). Tracing personal deixis (e.g. we, us, our, they, them, their) allowed us to observe the interviewee's allegiance and non-allegiance to certain groups described in the story, and her construction of her own agency in the actions recounted in the story. Analysing spatial deixis (e.g. there, here, at the top, at the bottom) enabled us to see the interviewee's self-positioning as regards hierarchical subordination or superiority. Examining different temporal deixis (e.g. then, now, in the beginning) allowed us to explore the scope of

different phases of the stories that were told (What was then? Why? And what is now? What has changed? Why?).

On the basis of this microanalysis, we went through all of the identified stories in order to detect a storyline – that is, the basic point that we thought the interviewee was making about the practical operation of ministry–agency interactions and the changes associated with the agency reform (Feldman *et al.* 2004, p. 154). In addition to this inductive approach, we also performed a more deductive analysis by drawing on the above-described analytical heuristic of boundary work which was refined over the course of analysing the stories.

In the second step of analysis, we located our preliminary interpretations of the stories within a multilayered context. In doing this, we drew on our knowledge of (a) the local *mesocontext* of the organizational social and political spaces studied, as well as our knowledge of (b) the *macrocontext* of policy and administrative traditions (Bevir and Rhodes 2003, p. 71).

With all identified stories and storylines from the transcript at hand, we used a collaborative process to identify two main storylines. One storyline was about the conflicts caused by what we interpreted as practices of expansion becoming especially visible in the early years of the reform. Another storyline was about how the organizations involved arrived at a consensus regarding the overall success of the new agency model, which we interpreted as a story of strategic adaptation occurring during the phase of objectification according to our analytical heuristic. Before we present our findings, the next section first briefly sketches out the institutional and discursive context of the German food safety administration.

GERMAN FOOD SAFETY ADMINISTRATION IN CONTEXT

In Germany, scientific policy advice is most commonly organized in the form of ‘governmental research agencies’ (GRAs) that are usually ‘multiple purpose organizations’ performing various administrative and regulatory tasks in addition to conducting research and giving scientific policy advice (Bach and Döhler 2012, p. 6). As a consequence of the German ‘departmental principle’ and the doctrine of ministerial responsibility, GRAs (and indeed almost all German federal agencies) are traditionally subject to full ministerial (legal *and* functional) oversight. Due to their hybrid accountabilities to the political and the scientific sphere, GRAs are traditionally perceived as being both scientifically valid and politically relevant and legitimate expert bodies.

In the wake of the German BSE crisis, however, the federal GRAs responsible for food safety were blamed for having failed to assess, manage, and communicate scientific evidence neutrally and openly (von Wedel 2001). As a result, the organization of the science–policy nexus in food safety policy, never a politically salient but rather a technical issue, became a front-stage political theme. Coherent and objective and therewith credible risk assessment and communication came to be defined as something that required more scientific autonomy than traditionally assigned to GRAs (Jung and Korinek 2014).

Accordingly, the scientific advisory system in food safety policy was fundamentally reorganized in 2001–02 (Janning 2011, pp. 158–65). The Federal Institute for Health Protection of Consumer and Veterinary Medicine (BgVV) was dissolved, and two new single-purpose organizations were created in its place: one scientific risk assessment and risk communication agency, the Federal Institute for Risk Assessment (BfR); and one risk management agency, the Federal Office of Consumer Protection (BVL).¹

The BfR is responsible for producing scientific opinions on the risks to human health from food, chemicals, and other consumer products either on request or on its own initiative. The recipients of these recommendations are the various federal ministries, mainly the Federal Ministry for Consumer Protection, Food and Agriculture (BMELV) and the risk management agency BVL, which conducts authorization procedures. Since the establishment of the BfR in 2002, the number of risk assessments produced per year has increased from 2,200 to 3,080 in 2012 (BfR 2012, p. 8), indicating regular interactions with ministries. The BfR conducts its own research and runs national reference laboratories in a number of fields. One of the main characteristics of the BfR is its formal autonomy in terms of risk research and public communication. The BfR was initially composed of former staff members from its predecessor agency, the BgVV. Today it has 756 employees (BfR 2012, p. 8).

The BVL is responsible for authorization and risk management, fulfilling various coordination and service tasks both for EU-level bodies and for the federal states (*Länder*). On the national level, the BVL is responsible for crisis management and for managing authorization procedures, for example for plant protection substances, veterinary medical products, and genetically modified organisms. In contrast to the BfR, the BVL is subject to BMELV's legal and functional oversight. On authorization procedures, there is very close cooperation between the BVL and the BfR; the majority of BfR risk assessments are part of the authorization procedures conducted by the BVL. Like the BfR, the BVL is a successor organization of the BgVV. Today, it employs around 522 staff members.

Summing up, the special character and history of the federal food safety administration makes it a particularly suitable setting to study, from a longitudinal perspective, one of the key questions in agencification research: How do the intra- and inter-organizational role understandings and practices in ministry–agency interactions change when a multipurpose organization previously under full ministerial supervision formally becomes a semi-autonomous, single-purpose organization?

BOUNDARY DISCOURSES IN MINISTRY–AGENCY INTERACTIONS

In the following, we will reconstruct the changing boundary work discourses within two different phases of the institutionalization processes (habitualization, objectification). Looking back at more than one decade of operational practice, there is a clear awareness among all the interviewees that the implementation of the separation model was (and sometimes still is) not without problems, conflicts, and dilemmas that required particular management practices in order to be solved. The next section deals with how such boundary conflicts were played out in the phase of habitualization.

Habitualization: What does it mean to be an 'independent risk assessor'?

When we asked about 'critical moments' in the implementation phase of the reform model, we were told a story in which conflicts over new roles and rules disturbed the inter-organizational workflow in the early days of the new organizational arrangement. What was highly controversial was the question of how the concept of an independent risk assessment and communication should relate to the scope of political definitional power in risk management. The reform in 2002 made providing legal evaluations and policy recommendations the exclusive task of the BVL. However, the way the BfR started

to engage with the new reform model was informed by its traditional self-understanding as a 'multipurpose' organization whose remit included both assessing risks scientifically and evaluating policy and legal implications. As such, the members of the BfR's predecessor organization were explicitly required to consider political and legal constraints in their work. However, after the reform, the ministry and the BVL perceived the inclusion of concrete policy recommendations and legal evaluations in the BfR's risk assessment reports as an 'inappropriate overstepping of its domain of authority' (#7). They expected the BfR to provide a range of more general policy options and not just formulate single and detailed policy recommendations including legal evaluations.

In addition to sticking to its 'old' identity as a multipurpose organization, the BfR increasingly internalized the newly assigned 'public education function' as part of its identity. The agency now perceived itself as a 'scientific corrective' (#1,5) to the political sphere, 'established with the aim of balancing the [political] unwillingness to communicate' (#1). From the risk managers' perspective, this self-description was not without its problems because it ignored their demands for independent risk communication. As one official complained: '*the difficulty was then, if someone is an independent scientist, he will tend to say things immediately and clearly, just like his profession and also his mandate dictates, and in addition, possibly also will give a recommendation for action. And then there is the expectation behind this: I have done all this scientific work, ... and, actually, I have given them recommendations 1, 2, 3 of what to do*' (#2). A colleague remembered the initial problems of independent risk communication in a similar way: 'Because you are obliged to educate the public, and then you tend to immediately put many things online. And that is not always a good thing' (#4).

As these quotations demonstrate, providing anything more than purely scientific risk assessments here is framed as stepping outside the agency's domain of authority. In addition, as the italicized words highlight, understanding the 'public education' mandate as a purely scientific task – that is, a task that should be carried out exclusively on the basis of scientific norms and standards (e.g. publish or perish; linguistic precision) – is deemed an illegitimate and dysfunctional expansion of the new agency's authority.

The ministry regularly felt 'put on the spot when a blockbuster runs through the news ticker at 5 p.m. on Friday' (#2). This quote uses emotive language to refer to the BfR's initial practice of publishing scientific risk assessment results, typically prompting immediate media interest, without informing the ministry in advance. The ministry was denied a time buffer in order to become acquainted with the case or to at least allow the ministry to prepare a press release for the minister. As a consequence, it often 'felt driven' (#2,3) by the BfR in the early years after the reform.

In the face of these dilemmas, the key challenges perceived were learning to give the ministry time buffers to prepare public statements, and giving the ministry and the BVL room for manoeuvre in risk management. Constitutive of granting politico-administrative room for manoeuvre was developing a language reflecting the ministry's and the BVL's autonomy in risk management, thereby modifying the agency's autonomy in risk communication in response to politico-administrative demands.² For the ministry, the BfR's autonomy in public risk communication required using 'language, that doesn't contain any risk management instructions and is comprehensible' – that is, language that avoids 'stumbling blocks in the communication', such as the use of 'should' instead of 'must' and is not 'replete with references' (#3).

Habitualization: What does it mean to be a risk manager?

The interpretive conflicts did not solely focus on the independent risk assessor role but also on the role of the ministry and the BfR as risk managers. Initially, ministry staff stuck to their traditional self-understanding as the 'hierarchical superiors' of the BfR staff, and to the norm of command and control that this identity implies. The fact that the BfR was now formally independent in risk communication particularly challenged the ministry's established self-understanding. Several interviewees saw the ministry's continued attempt to 'prevent certain things from being published, or to postpone their publication' (#5) as an expression of its adherence to its former identity. In keeping with its traditional identity, it also continued to regard the BfR as its 'extended workbench' (#5) with the implication that ministry officials 'liked to create their own feel-good area within the BfR' (#5). Just as had been the norm beforehand, some junior-level officers expected the BfR's scientists to give advice or to carry out work orders 'at the snap of the fingers' (#5).

However, to the BfR the ministry's behaviour was an inappropriate intrusion into 'internal issues and procedures' (#1), which its new mandate defined as autonomous from ministerial interventions. It felt negatively affected by the ministry's uncoordinated hierarchical interventions and bilateral requesting practices, which caused work overloads in the agency. Moreover, the BfR felt impeded in its mission to speak with one voice, which was seen as a precondition for becoming accepted as a 'reference authority' (#1,5,3) in food safety policy – that is, being deemed as an authoritative voice vis-à-vis both critics from social interest groups and media as well as other experts in the field.

However, convincing the ministry that the only appropriate option was to adjust its role and adopt a more horizontal interactional pattern vis-à-vis the BfR was no easy task. Ministerial officials 'were not amused, when they called us [the BfR] and then were not served on the spot' (#5). The ministry's initial difficulties in letting go of their former role as the 'hierarchical superior' was further described by another BfR staff member: 'Of course, according to the ministry's understanding, something like our organization doesn't exist, because for them it's simply unimaginable that there is an organization, and although it's financed by the ministry, it is still able to do whatever it wants' (#6). Thus, the BfR realized that maintaining its formal autonomy in risk assessment and communication would pose a challenge.

One of its first steps along this road was making clear that the ministry needed to adjust to the idea that the BfR was autonomous in defining its internal and external working practices and that this was necessary in order to restore consumer trust. In this context, the ability of the agency's president to cope with conflicts was seen as a crucial element: 'as a former professor ... who had just entered the organization and therefore had no BgVV or BGA experience, he knew that he had the mandate, we are allowed and are expected to independently assess and communicate risks' (#5).

To sum up, we have illustrated in the examples above how the boundary between the forms of autonomy and control that were considered legitimate and necessary and the forms of autonomy/control that were deemed illegitimate and dysfunctional were drawn in different ways. Informed by their identities, actors attributed differing meanings to the concept of scientific autonomy and deployed these ambiguous and contested understandings in renegotiating roles and rules in ministry–agency interactions. According to our heuristic we can interpret these observations as 'discourses of expansion'. Autonomy is, on the one hand, thought of as a means of monopolizing risk communication and policy advice: by referring to the concept of scientific autonomy, the political expectations attributed to the practical operation of risk communication are disclaimed here

as normatively illegitimate. Agency autonomy, in turn, is justified by the public education function attributed to scientific experts. On the other hand, the dominant claim is that understanding autonomous risk communication as an exclusively scientific task creates dysfunction. What follows is an exploration of how these conflicting interpretations resulting in expansion discourses came to be reconciled by using different boundary management practices.

Objectification: Boundary management as conflict management

Coming to shared understandings of new roles and rules was a challenging process: 'We underwent a *learning*, a *thinking* process, which *we*, *here*, and *also the staff*, still had to develop *in the course of time* ... if you introduce new rules, it normally takes four, five, six years *until they reach the bottom down there*' (#3). This 'learning' and 'thinking process' was fundamentally about redefining the new organization model as a strategic 'success story' within a crisis-plagued and contested policy field. As the above italicized words suggest, for organization members the process of accepting this story has been a very lengthy one requiring considerable effort to establish top-down management. Let us first have a closer look at how the new governance model is narrated as a strategic success story, before exploring the different boundary management practices used to enforce this harmonizing success story.

Managing boundary conflicts through strategic success stories

A constitutive element of the success story, which we read as 'meta' practice of conflict management used for the resocialization of organization members, is portraying the relationship between the ministry and the BfR as a strategic relationship serving the institutional self-interest of both. As a ministerial staff member put it: 'And if you ask me what has changed? Simply the acceptance of the BfR as an independent scientific institution in the public, in the multiplier groups has increased. And that's the success, to place a new institution on the market in a relatively short time frame and get it to the point where what this institution says is considered equally credible by the media and the consumers. And with this in mind, one can also argue that this has resulted in increased consumer "trust in science" (#8).

Hence, the success story commences by pointing out the BfR's increased public acceptance. It then proceeds by explaining why public acceptance, here the attribution of credibility, is such an important indicator for assessing the success of the agency. An independent agency is politically useful because it functions as an epistemic authority in a contested field – that is, in a 'market' where various experts are competing for credibility. Autonomy here is, in short, justified by the epistemic authority attributed to an independent agency.

We also find a very similar and extensive discussion of the benefits of an independent single-purpose agency providing exclusively scientific advice in the BfR's narratives: 'One has recognized in the policy field that here you have, let's say, to place the reference function of science in the foreground, although, at the bottom, this is a substitute, I would say, for political decisions or the delegation of political decision making' (#1). Once again, the loss of political primacy in risk communication is justified by recourse to the new agency's epistemic authority. It is important to note that what is described as a 'learning process' here is 'to place the reference function of science in the foreground', although *de facto* ('at the bottom') this means the 'replacement' of political authority. Thus, in this passage it

becomes clear that the strategic adaptation narrative is indeed used as a discursive device of boundary management.

The epistemic 'reference function' is further portrayed as all the more important where 'the distinction between good and bad science, ... is indeed a crucial one'. In such an environment, the BfR is portrayed as 'the sole agency in Germany whose core task is giving good advice to them [the government] and that's indeed the case. We are the sole agency giving exclusively good advice because we don't stamp and don't authorize and that makes it special, because the question is, how to deal with second-best advice? And how to bring your people to a standard that ensures that the public regards the BfR as a reference' (#1).

These sequences frame agency autonomy as a strategic necessity. Through its independence, the knowledge the BfR produces is apt to be considered 'good science', which can be demarcated from 'bad science'. Thus, the benefit of agency autonomy in risk communication here is the generation and reassertion of epistemic authority in a politically and epistemically contested policy field.

However, as should be clear from our previous analysis, this success story, which relies on the mutual strategic benefit of the separation model, had to compete with counter narratives. To manage these acceptance problems, the leadership in both organizations used various coordination practices as means of resocializing organization members and enabling a working consensus over new roles and rules to emerge.

Managing boundary conflicts through bureaucratic coordination

We call the first set of boundary management practices used to enforce the strategic adaptation narrative 'bureaucratic coordination' – that is, the targeted and enhanced use of classical intra- and inter-organizational coordination practices of German ministerial bureaucracy. One practice was to gradually undermine what was perceived as a scientific monopolization of risk communication by defining the BfR's role not only with reference to its research activities and scientific expertise, but also on the basis of its responsibilities as an agency, that is, as a part of the politico-administrative system.

First and unsurprisingly, this meant fulfilling the ministerial expectation of 'being in constant touch' (#2), and hence keeping the ministry informed about politically and administratively important issues in the work of the agency. In particular in the early days of the BfR, its president and vice-president were invited to weekly, sometimes even daily, telephone conversations or meetings with the ministry. Second, a 'no surprises rule' (#2,5,6) was agreed upon in order to give the ministry the chance to prepare press releases and coordinate a media or stakeholder communication strategy. According to this rule, the BfR's risk assessment reports are to be submitted to the ministry at least 24 hours prior to publication. The BfR acknowledged the general importance of such time buffers for political actors because they have learned to regard them as a prerequisite for the politico-administrative capacity to act. Today, this rule is seen as a 'self-evident professional practice in good relationships' (#8).

Conversely, a central means of avoiding the ministry's interventions in what came to be defined as the BfR's 'internal working procedures' (#1,5,6) was an additional classical bureaucratic coordination device, namely procedural formalization, centralization, and hierarchization. An informal rule was agreed according to which all ministerial requests have to be made by formal decree. This procedural formalization was accompanied by a

centralization of the intra-organizational workflow within both the ministry and the BfR. Within the BMELV, the section that was charged with supervising the department's subordinated agencies was assigned the distinct task of monitoring the implementation of reorganization. One of the section's prime tasks at that time was fostering change in the ministry's tradition of secrecy to bring about a 'culture of openness and transparency' where 'consumer information is now the central pillar' (#3). A cultural change of this magnitude did not proceed without triggering conflicts within the ministry.

During the internal discussions concerning the ministry's new role, 'in some situations, some people lost patience' (#8). Over time, the ministry's leadership managed to internally achieve a 'change of consciousness': the ministry internally succeeded in centralizing communication with the BfR in order to avoid ministerial interventions and bilateral requests, which gradually came to be seen as running counter to the mutual goal of having an agency 'speaking with one voice' (#1,2,5). This centralization implies that the line organization's requests to the BfR always have to pass the desks of the respective section leader and of the head of division.

The BfR also introduced new internal hierarchies and underwent a process of centralization in order to enable the agency to speak to the political sphere and the public with one voice. As a result, each ministerial decree is now first processed in the clearing unit within the division for risk communication. The clearing unit then makes a suggestion to the president regarding which particular division or expert group should have responsibility for processing the request. After the division or group in charge has responded to the request and, if necessary, coordinated with other divisions, the request is passed to the division for risk communication, and then back again to the president before it leaves the house.

Managing boundary conflicts through translation and standardization

Another boundary management practice involves adjusting the language of the scientific risk assessors to conform to politico-administrative and legal demands and rationalities (e.g. consistency with legal wording used in a court of law) by means of a legal-bureaucratic language regime. Here, the different rationalities of politics, law, and science, often entailing contradictory normative and cognitive expectations concerning the role of an independent scientific advisory agency, are translated into a language that is perceived as politically and legally robust. Moreover, the agency's leadership saw the need to agree on standardized risk assessment terminology, making use of, for instance, the term of 'verifying' instead of 'to find a measurement value' (#5) obligatory for its staff members.

In order to create intra-organizational capacities for these translation and standardization activities, the BfR's president established a new division for risk communication consisting of social scientists, psychologists, lawyers, and media experts. This division initiated the creation of a 'Guidance Document for Health Assessments' containing concrete formulations and definitions of risks, and thereby also serving as an internal coordination device: 'Because [the decision] whether the risk is now "high" or "medium high", or "likely", or "foreseeable" simply cannot be dependent on how person X or Y from division A or B pulls it out of his hat' (#5). These guidelines, which are revised every second year, standardize the use of terminology in a number of respects: terminology for risk characterization, recommended management options, codifying scientific uncertainties, the concordant use of legal terms, and referring to legal provisions (BfR 2010, pp. 6–24).

For example, the phrase 'health risks cannot be excluded' should be avoided as it has no merit in a court of law (p. 24).

The guidelines also regulate the overall structure and content of the reports, which now start with a small grey box including a short summary and the conclusions drawn from scientific research. According to the guidelines, this should not exceed one paragraph and should include an unambiguously formulated 'take home message' for politicians and the general public (BfR 2010, p. 12). This 'take home message' is particularly valued by the ministry as being 'definitely the guidelines' resounding success!' because it helps to translate the scientific findings into a 'politically useful' product (#2). For the ministry's leadership it is these translations that particularly justify and defend the autonomy of the BfR in risk communication when it is challenged by ministerial staff members attempting to have a say in risk communication: 'Then it also was my task, to hold direct talks with the initiators here in the house and to make clear that we have a different culture now, it may hurt you, but that's how it is, but consumer information is now a main pillar of our consumer policy and we have found someone who does this, who translates the complicated scientific language into a language which is also understood by the housewife in front of the stove, and that's the BfR and it does this independently' (#3).

Remarkably, this translation and standardization regime was accepted by the BfR's scientists because they gradually recognized that 'there is also a certain strategy of the house behind it!' (#5). The guideline's strategic use is seen in its function as a quality management tool that in turn serves to safeguard the BfR's scientists in disputes with other scientists or experts. Having also been published in English, the guidelines became 'an export hit, today, we even have a summer school with hundreds of applicants and they all learn how we, how Germany, does risk assessment' (#5). Moreover, the guidelines are strategically used to define the criteria for objectively assessing risks (BfR 2010, p. 6), which can then be used to publicly legitimate BfR's risk assessment practices. As a representative of the BfR explained, its internal risk assessment procedures are legitimated because they are defined in guidelines that are publicly accessible and transparent.

Throughout the interviews, the BfR's standardized approach to risk assessment is seen as a crucial tool that is assisting it on its path to becoming a 'reference authority' (#1,5,3) that can provide rules for resolving dissent among experts from European risk assessment agencies. According to the head of the communication division, the official guidance document is internally supplemented by a detailed 'no-go list' involving an ongoing collection of 'typically wrong wordings' (#5). The division for risk communication internally monitors risk assessors' compliance with both the guidelines and the 'no-go list'.

Summing up, what we see here is how in the phase of objectification the stories told changed. Autonomy and control, both of which had been framed by the other party as a dysfunctional and illegitimate authority expansion, now came to be portrayed as appropriate and legitimate for achieving their mutual, reflexive self-interested goals of gaining or maintaining political and epistemic authority in the food safety field. In this phase, the predominant story was about explaining to their own organization members why, where, and when precisely they should adapt to the other's demands. In telling this story, actors become more reflexive about their relation as independent risk assessors and risk managers whose hierarchical control competencies have been curtailed.

DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSION

The aim of this article was to understand how a new agency model situated at the science–policy nexus became institutionalized over time. We studied the microlevel of ministry–agency interactions as they unfolded – and changed – in practice over more than one decade. Our reconstruction of the empirical material was grounded in a heuristic of three different types of boundary work devices, which we expected to be hierarchically patterned according to the three phases of the institutionalization process (habitualization, objectification, sedimentation).

Agency autonomy as a discursive relational phenomenon

Using a narrative approach to agencification we were able to systematically analyse the way storytellers were making sense of their organizational realities after these had changed in an agencification reform and how they renegotiated new roles and rules applying to their relationship within a lengthy iterative process. In the contested food safety field, one of the central identity norms concerns the objectivity (here in the sense of disinterestedness from political or business interests) and scientific validity with which food risks are assessed and communicated. The stories we were told were about how actors worked to enact objectivity and validity, thereby renegotiating when, where, and why the ministry should concede scientific expert autonomy. Likewise, as much as objectivity and validity are constitutive norms of science, value-based decision-making is the identity constituting norm of politics. Thus, not only were the modes of ministerial adaptation to the BfR's rationality as a scientific advisory organization renegotiated but also when, where, and why the BfR should adapt to politico-administrative demands in order to grant the ministry room for political manoeuvre in relation to the agency's independent risk communication.

The perspective applied in this article thus highlights the qualitative and dynamic (rather than quantitative) nature of changes in ministry–agency interactions following agencification reforms. Accordingly, our suggestion for future research is twofold: we propose considering agency autonomy as the dynamic and tense discursive intertwining of autonomy demands on the one hand and utility expectations on the other hand and thus as a discursive relational phenomenon (Jung 2014). Moreover, we propose that the institutionalization of agencification reforms should be seen as a process in which actors become more *reflexive* concerning their own organizational identity in relation to other organizational identities in changing social environments, rather than as a matter of higher or lower degrees of autonomy.

Backstage coordination and front-stage reputation

Our empirical findings offer some constitutive insights that refine the strand of agencification literature focusing on reputation management as a key resource for formally independent agencies, which allows them to create and cultivate *de facto* autonomy (Carpenter and Krause 2012). In the stories examined, conceding *de facto* agency autonomy has consistently been framed as an effective means of guaranteeing that the agency meets expectations regarding its front-stage reputation, which involves producing risk assessments that are deemed both scientifically valid and objective *and* relevant and robust by stakeholders and the wider public. However, as our findings show, the ability to speak with one unified voice and to produce reports that are deemed objective and robust cannot be taken for granted; it is something that demands 'backstage management' – that is, a tight coordination regime carefully concealed from the public (Hilgartner 2000).

Legally robust reports imply not only that they are deemed to be based on 'sound science', but also that they are written using standardized legal terminology. Likewise, socially robust risk assessment reports require not only the public attribution of scientific validity and objectivity, but also easily comprehensible language. To fulfil these multiple front-stage reputation requirements, both the ministry and the BfR have had to undergo considerable intra-organizational hierarchization, centralization, and formalization. Constructing the de facto autonomy of the agency as a whole required the individual ministerial officials and risk assessors within the BfR to adapt to leadership expectations. Yet, the story of strategic adaptation was at first only shared by the leadership of both organizations; its acceptance at the lower levels required a lengthy process of top-down management.

Drawing on these empirical results, our proposition for future research would be that researchers should, rather than treating the expert authority of independent agencies as a pre-existing property, examine how it is actively constructed by means of a carefully orchestrated interplay between 'front-stage performances' and 'backstage management' practices involving the development of intra-organizational hierarchization, centralization, and formalization (Hilgartner 2000; Hajer 2009; Korinek 2014).

The discursive embeddedness of agencification

Our findings suggest that boundary management practices and the working consensus established through these practices are constitutively shaped by policy discourses framing particular policy problems and policy solutions. The fundamental shift in the framing of food safety policy that occurred in response to the BSE crisis had implications for what the legitimate function of the science-based expertise produced by advisory agencies is deemed to be, namely 'public education' that aims to enable consumers to make rational choices on food risks. It is precisely in terms of this function that agency autonomy is construed as a rational (utility argument) and a legitimate (normative argument) solution to the policy problem of a dramatic loss of consumer trust. Thus, in terms of future research we argue that to account for the identified patterns of de facto agency autonomy, we must ask how policy problems were construed in different policy sectors, and how these policy ideas are re-embedded into existing boundary management practices.

Of course, these propositions draw on a single case study and thus their generalizability needs to be explored in cross-national and/or cross-sectoral comparative studies. Notwithstanding the caveats concerning single case studies' generalizability, our analysis underlines the added value of focusing on the microlevel of organizations and the negotiation of boundaries (boundary work) in order to understand the mechanisms involved in institutionalizing organizational change that remain – despite some important steps made – to a surprising degree an unexamined issue in the existing literature. With this article we hope to have made a further contribution in opening the 'black box' of intra- and inter-organizational micropactices in ministry–agency relationships.

ACKNOWLEDGEMENTS

The interviews on which this article is based were conducted in the context of the research project 'Studying the Changing Orders of Political Expertise' (SCOPE), carried out at the WZB Berlin Social Science Center and funded by the Volkswagen Foundation. Interview contributions from the Federal Ministry for Consumer Protection, Food and Agriculture

(BMELV), the Federal Office of Consumer Protection (BVL), and the Federal Institute for Risk Assessment (BfR) are gratefully acknowledged. In addition to two anonymous reviewers, we would also like to thank the participants of the panel ‘Does Administrative Structure Matter? The Effects of Agencification on the Policy Process’ at the XXII IPSA World Congress of Political Science in Madrid, and the members of the Research Group ‘Science Policy’ at the WZB for very helpful comments on earlier versions of this article.

NOTES

¹ This reorganization followed the institutional design of the EU-level administration, where, since 2002, risk assessment is carried out separately from risk management.

² In addition, sufficiently taking into account issues of commercial confidentiality was regarded as a precondition for politico-administrative room for manoeuvre.

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